

EVEN WAR HAS RULES

THE GENEVA CONVENTIONS
(1864, 1906, 1929, 1949)



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

International law

BEFORE

1337–1453 During the Hundred Years' War, Richard II and Henry V of England and Charles VII of France each try to codify military discipline.

1863 Abraham Lincoln adopts the Lieber Code on the ethical treatment of civilians during the Civil War.

AFTER

1977 Two protocols are added to the Geneva Conventions; one covers internal conflicts.

1998 The Rome Statute agrees to establish the International Criminal Court in The Hague, in the Netherlands.

1999 Yugoslav president Slobodan Milošević is the first sitting head of state to be charged with war crimes.

The Geneva Conventions comprise four treaties adopted between 1864 and 1949 and are based on the principle of public international law that is applicable to armed conflicts. The Conventions lay out a minimum standard for the humane treatment of both combatants and civilians who become victims of war to ensure that life is respected.

The idea for an internationally adopted set of rules to prevent suffering during war was first proposed in 1862 by Henry Dunant, a Swiss businessman. Dunant had traveled to northern Italy to request water rights for a business venture from Napoleon III of France, who